

Camsail Annual Chairman's Report for 2021-2022

It was very good to meet once again in person, after the 2020-2021 season when all our meetings had been online because of Covid. However, we fully understood that numbers at our meetings were lower than before the pandemic; we know that a number of our stalwart members had not felt able to attend any meetings during the season. We were very grateful for the continued support of all those who had paid their membership subscription (including nine who had not been able to attend any meetings!). We finished the season with 49 members, virtually unchanged from where we were before the pandemic. We do take this as a mark of confidence in Camsail. It had been good to welcome a few new to us during the season.

October: Perhaps the spirit of Arthur Ransome lives on through his boat the Nancy Blackett. Bryan Davies, one of the Trust's volunteer skippers, told us how she had been rescued from becoming derelict by a restoration taking many years. The costs were high because great care was taken to make her as similar to the original boat as possible. Most items needed had to be handmade by experts, rather than coming from of a yacht chandler's shelf. Nowadays 'Nancy' is used to introduce to sailing a wide variety of people - many of whom had probably never read any of Ransome's books about children using their imagination to have adventures on a rowing boat in the waters of the Lake District. Bryan and his fellow skippers are doing a great job providing opportunities for newbies to enjoy a wonderful activity in a unique boat and then, of course, step into the luxury, by comparison, of comfortable cruising yachts!

November: Ben Edwards' talk of his experience as a 14 year old aboard a 49 ft yacht, the Northabout, for 4.5 months in the Arctic was amazing. The purpose of the circumnavigation of the globe around the North Pole, through the North East and North West Passages in one season, was to highlight the decreasing sea ice in the Arctic Ocean. We have perhaps become more familiar with films from the Arctic by David Attenborough, but Ben's accounts of sea ice, polar bears and a hurricane enjoyed/shared with a constantly changing crew, not all English-speaking, was very moving and much appreciated by his audience. He has also written a very well illustrated book, the profits of which all go to charity.

December: In spite of the Committee's worry about Covid preventing people from attending the Members' evening, there was a good turnout and an enjoyable nautical/Christmas party took place, which included the showing of the film of Leg 3 of the Clipper Race 2009/2010 (Cape Town to Australia) - where 'Cork' collided with 'Hull and Humber' at the start, causing severe damage.

February: The East Anglian Sailing Trust is a charitable organisation whose aim is to provide children and adults with disabilities regular opportunities to access and enjoy sailing activities. The scheme involves an experienced skipper from the Trust, together with the boat owner, the disabled person and their carer, going sailing together. The speakers (Ian Jewry & Simon Daws) were encouraging us to volunteer out boats. I have not heard of anyone who has offered his/her boat, but I have met a skipper who regularly has a legless crew who gets himself on board from the pontoon in an amazingly spritely fashion; an army veteran, he sails regularly. We were surprised that EAST is one of very few organisations, possibly the only charity, working in this area. The details of technological help for visually impaired sailors was very interesting.

March: 'The Big Dig' was largely an account of how a small group of determined men created a very successful business over many years. They were local people, mostly with sailing interests, who must have appreciated that the bend in the River Orwell downstream from Levington would be a good place to keep a boat. Between them, they possessed a wide range of skills, knowledge and resources, were friends, and latterly had the strong, kind and amiable leadership of our speaker, Jonathan Dyke. The tale of the history of Suffolk Yacht Harbour was told with enthusiasm, humour, and was a very good example for entrepreneurs. This meeting had originally been planned for January, but, in the light of the increased Covid infection rates after Christmas, we decided not to meet then. Fortunately our speaker agreed to transfer to the March meeting.

April: Cruising from Marseille to Honfleur really has nothing to do with sailing, but having reached the Rhone delta, rather than taking the sea route back home, you can avoid a supposedly NE trade wind up the Atlantic by going up the Rhone. Best without a mast for boats over 32 ft, lots of low bridges, narrow locks and in places it can be quite crowded. It can be the cruise of a lifetime, so very much more interesting than being on a cruise ship/liner. [We persuaded Peter Jones to repeat this very interesting talk which he had given to us in 2013 – Ed.]

At the last meeting, we publicly thanked the Officers of the Cambridge and County Bowling Club, our hosts. Eric Simpson has been a friendly and welcoming face behind the bar for many years, while he has held every senior position in their club. He is taking a step back from some of those responsibilities, and we have been getting to know Andy Doble, their new Secretary, behind the bar. He has also been very friendly and cooperative. We owe a lot to them.

In May, there were two very well supported day trips to the National Trust Nature Reserve at Orford Ness; altogether 36 members and partners took part. We will hear reports from these trips at the Members' Meeting in December.